

French philosopher

René Descartes

Where France

When 1596–1650

Often called “the first modern philosopher,” French thinker René Descartes broke away from the ancient philosophies and took a new, scientific approach. His statement “*I think, therefore I am*” explains how his ability to think was proof of his own existence. Descartes’ ideas form a starting point for much of later philosophy, but he also wrote on scientific subjects as well. His mathematical ideas inspired physicist Isaac Newton’s theories on the laws of motion.



1750–1900

American sociologist

W. E. B Du Bois

Where US

When 1868–1963

Du Bois was a pioneer in the field of sociology. For more than a decade, he studied discrimination against Black Americans. His findings drove him to become a civil rights campaigner who fought racism and injustice. He encouraged the Black community to fight for equality through political agitation.



French feminist

Simone de Beauvoir

Where France

When 1908–1986

A great philosopher and teacher, de Beauvoir is widely regarded as the pioneer of feminism. Her best-known book, *The Second Sex* (1949), states that society tells women how to behave and controls them by ranking them lower than men. She encouraged women to choose their own path instead of conforming to society’s idea of what they should be.



British philosopher

Philippa Foot

Where England

When 1920–2010

One of the leading 20th-century philosophers, Philippa Foot focused on the area of ethics (how we should behave). She was influenced by the teachings of Aristotle and shared his belief that what mattered most in people was their moral character and essential virtues. Her writings are an essential part of modern moral philosophy.

